

Leonardo

Painter, sculptor, inventor, engineer, scientist, architect, designer and musician, Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519) was the archetypal 'Renaissance man'. Incessantly curious, he filled many notebooks with sketches, diagrams and mirror writing, as he worked out engineering, anatomical and artistic problems.

After training with Verrocchio, Leonardo worked as a painter in Florence, using cadavers to study human anatomy and proportion. Only about 17 paintings survive that have been attributed to him, but he also made many drawings. He painted using effects including soft tonal modulations, or *sfumato*, and portrayed reflective emotions and graceful poses. Fascinated by reading the 'motions of the soul' through expression and gesture, his works were enigmatic and alluring. Moving to Milan as an artist and military engineer for the ruling Sforza family, he painted *The Last Supper* for the refectory of Santa Maria della Grazie. He later worked in Rome, Bologna and Venice, and spent the last years of his life in France, a guest of King Francis I.



Leonardo, *The Mona Lisa*, c.1505